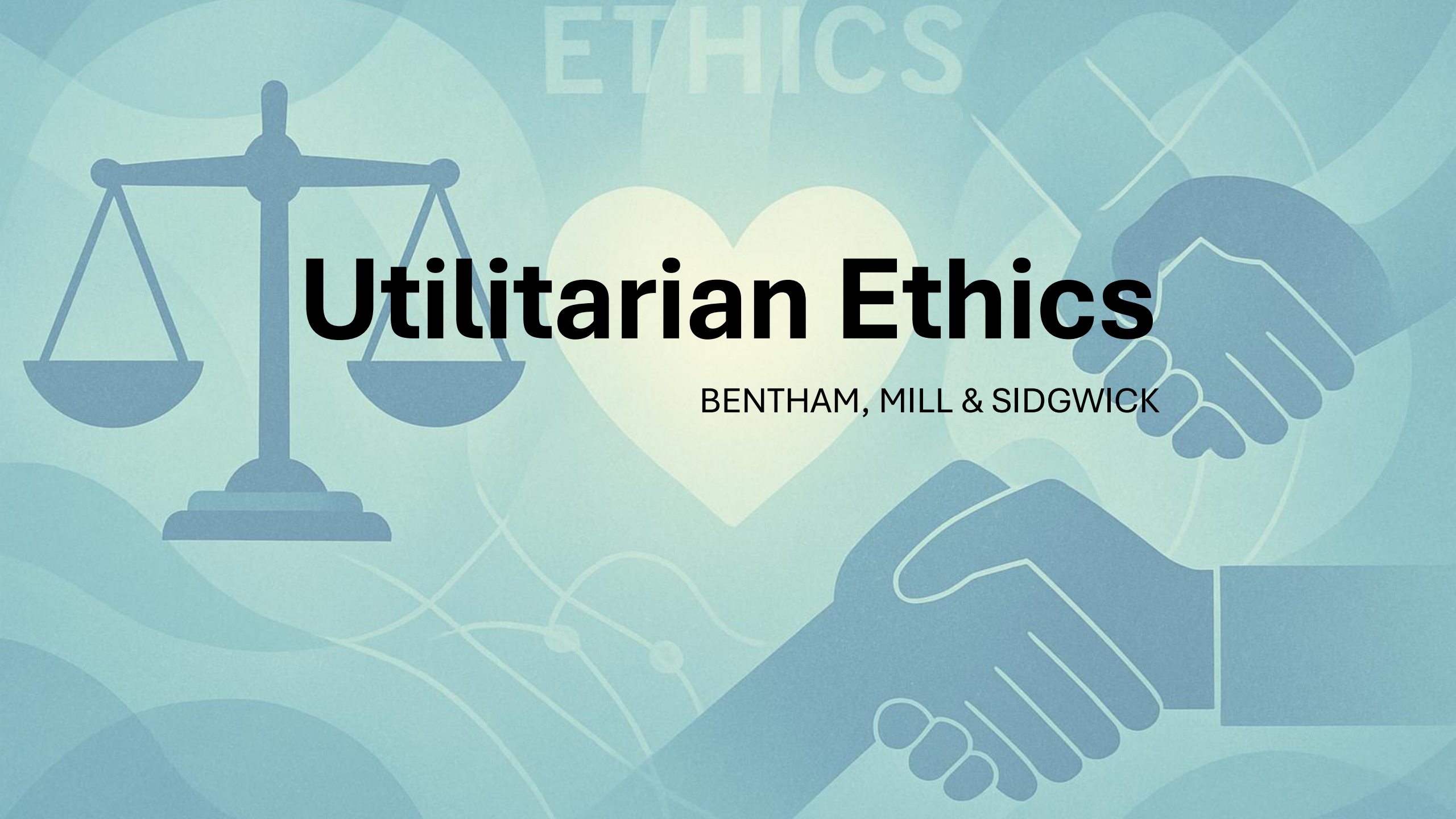


Utilitarian Ethics

BENTHAM, MILL & SIDGWICK

Introduction to Utilitarianism:

Moral theory attempts to provide a systematic account of morality as a normative system.

Normative ethics is the area of philosophy concerned with **standards for right conduct and moral evaluation**.

Utilitarianism is a prominent example of a **teleological theory**, which defines **the good without reference to the right**, and then defines **the right as what promotes the good**.

It primarily focuses on the **consequences** of actions to determine their rightness.

Core Principle:

The fundamental principle of utilitarianism states that an action, or a law, is **right if it produces the best outcome**.

This is often articulated as bringing about the **"greatest good for the greatest number"**.

The "good" to be maximised is generally defined as **pleasure and the absence of pain (hedonism)**. Therefore, the right action maximises the balance of pleasure over pain, summed over all sentient beings affected by that action.

A key aspect is **impartiality**, meaning that everyone is to count for one, and no one for more than one, in the calculation of overall happiness.

Key Figures and Historical Context:

Eighteenth Century:

Francis Hutcheson and **David Hume** defended the utilitarian doctrine (without explicitly using the term "utilitarianism") based on their sentimentalist meta-ethics. They believed the "moral sense" approves actions from an impartial, disinterested, and sympathetic viewpoint that favours the maximum possible total good.

Nineteenth Century:

Jeremy Bentham applied the utilitarian criterion to specific laws, aiming to expose flaws in existing social practices and to promote overall societal welfare. His ideas significantly influenced later utilitarians.
John Stuart Mill and **Henry Sidgwick** are considered the most powerful philosophical defenders of utilitarianism in this period.
They championed utilitarianism as a **progressive doctrine** in morals and politics, advocating for social and political reforms to reduce inherited power, extend individual rights, and protect the welfare of the less fortunate members of society.

Direct vs. Indirect Utilitarianism:

This distinction concerns **how the principle of utility is applied** to actions or rules.

Direct Utilitarianism (Act Utilitarianism):
Requires the agent to strive for the **greatest overall happiness in *every specific action***.
All virtues and obligations are subordinate to this explicit and exclusive reference to utility.
William Godwin is an example, arguing that one should save the life of a great benefactor over a parent or child if it promises greater future benefits for humanity.

Indirect Utilitarianism (Rule Utilitarianism):
Maintains that desirable consequences are achieved **if agents follow general rules or systems** that, when universally adopted, lead to the greatest good, even if a particular act following the rule might not maximise utility in that specific instance.
John Stuart Mill believed that overall utility is maximised when society relies on **non-utilitarian "secondary principles"** (e.g., rules of justice or promises) in day-to-day decisions, rather than constantly applying the principle of utility directly.
Henry Sidgwick even considered that utilitarianism might be an "esoteric doctrine" not to be widely broadcast, as constant explicit application by individuals might hinder the achievement of overall good.

Quantitative vs. Qualitative Hedonism:

This distinction pertains to the **nature of the good (pleasure) to be maximised** within hedonistic utilitarianism.

Quantitative Hedonism:
Focuses solely on the **amount** or **duration** of pleasure.
It treats pleasure as a uniform sensation that can be measured and compared across different experiences, implying that a large quantity of a "lower" pleasure could outweigh a smaller quantity of a "higher" pleasure.
Henry Sidgwick explicitly advocated for quantitative hedonism as the only sound basis for a coherent theory of moral rightness.

Qualitative Hedonism:
Proposed by **John Stuart Mill**, this view posits that some pleasures are **inherently higher in quality** than others, irrespective of their quantity.Mill argued that intellectual, moral, and aesthetic pleasures are of a superior quality to mere sensual pleasures, stating that it is "better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied".He linked this to human dignity and the development of human capacities.
This approach aimed to defend utilitarianism against criticisms that it reduced human well-being to base, animalistic desires.However, the consistency of qualitative hedonism with the core hedonist belief that **pleasure is the *only* non-instrumental good** has been debated.

SUMMARY:

Utilitarianism, as a teleological moral theory, is founded on the principle of **maximising the good**, typically understood as pleasure, for the greatest number.

It has evolved through various forms, including **direct vs. indirect** applications and debates over **quantitative vs. qualitative** definitions of pleasure, adapting to philosophical challenges and practical implications.

Despite enduring criticisms, its emphasis on **consequences, impartiality, and overall well-being** ensures its continued influence as a foundational approach in ethical theory and public policy discussions.

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